to make his way to the top and set up a meteorological observatory there. This enabled Caldwell to state that rainfall there was twelve times more than what it was in the Tirunelveli plains: ‘Here we see the reason why it is that, though the plains of Tinnevelly are so parched and dry, and though the rainfall is so insignificant, the Tamraparni rolls to the sea its full flood of fertilising waters twice every year, and twice every year enriches the beautiful valley through which it flows with abundant crops.’

Fed by these distant rains, the farmers of Tirunelveli were able to plant and harvest twice a year, so that only the Cauvery River to the north produced greater yields. ‘Such a river would necessarily prove an attraction to settlers,’ Caldwell continues, ‘if not from the very first, yet at least from the first appearance in the district of a people systematically practising agriculture and acquainted with the cultivation of rice by irrigation.’

It was here in these silt-rich plains laced with numerous channels that the South’s first farming communities settled and prospered, leading to the first urban centres. Until the railways came along, long-distance movement between these population centres was chiefly by boat, up and down the coast and along the major river channels, giving rise to numerous ports along the coast and inland beside the rivers. Good roads were never a priority during British rule and it remained that way until after Independence in 1947, by which time population growth had put such a strain on the railway infrastructure that state governments were forced into major road-building programmes.

The creation of what are now South India’s well-managed and very profitable rice-bowls was the end result of the so-called Neolithic Revolution, which saw the transition from mobile hunter-gathering to the domestication of livestock and stock-breeding, and the planting and harvesting of cereal crops, accompanied by the storing of produce in granaries, and so homesteads, villages and towns. There is